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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

US targets transgender care for children

Proposal would cut funding for hospitals that provide treatment

By Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

In a move that could further reduce gender-affirming care for minors in Illinois, the federal government is proposing rules that would strip Medicare and Medicaid funding from hospitals that provide such services.

The administration of President Donald Trump has been threatening since early this year to block federal funding for hospitals that provide gender-affirming care to people younger than 18. The proposal announced Thursday is a concrete step toward making good on those threats.

The specter of losing federal funding already drove some Chicago-area hospital systems to scale back on their gender-affirming care for minors. Medicare and Medicaid are huge sources of funding for most hospitals. UChicago Medicine stopped providing gender-affirming pediatric care this summer, and Advocate Health Care said in August it would no longer provider gender-affirming medications to patients younger than 19.

A few Chicago-area hospital systems, however, have held out. Lurie Children's Hospital and UI Health halted gender-affirming surgeries for minors earlier this year but continued providing other types of gender-affirming care. Rush University System for Health stopped offering hormonal care to new patients under the age of 18 this summer.

Gender-affirming care can include a range of services such as puberty blockers, which are medications that delay puberty; hormone therapy, which can help individuals develop male or female characteristics; and surgeries to remove the breasts or alter genitals.

The federal proposals would block Medicare and Medicaid funding from hospitals perform-

Turn to Care, Page 5



Cardinal Timothy Dolan, right, and his successor, Ronald Hicks, arrive to lead a Mass at St. Patrick's Cathedral in the Manhattan borough of New York City on Thursday. Pope Leo XIV has accepted Dolan's resignation and named Joliet Bishop Hicks to replace him. **CHARLY TRIBALLEAU/GETTY-AFP**

Pope taps Joliet bishop to be archbishop of NY

Hicks replaces the retiring Cardinal Dolan to lead large, influential archdiocese

By Evy Lewis
and Nicole Winfield
Daily Southtown

Pope Leo XIV made his most important U.S. appointment to date Thursday, naming a fellow south suburbanite as the next archbishop of New York to lead one of the biggest archdioceses as it navigates relations with the Trump administration and its immigration crackdown.

Joliet Bishop Ronald Hicks will replace the retiring Cardinal Timothy Dolan, a prominent conservative figure in the U.S. Catholic hierarchy.

During a news conference in

New York Thursday morning, Hicks noted he grew up in South Holland, which is right next to Dolton in the south suburbs.

"South Holland and Dolton might not mean anything to you, but Dolton is where our holy father, Pope Leo XIV, grew up and is from, and our houses are literally 14 blocks away from each other," Hicks said.

Hicks will be installed as archbishop Feb. 6 at St. Patrick's Cathedral in New York, according to the Joliet Diocese. Until then, he will continue serving as bishop of Joliet, where he has been since 2020.

"The past five years in Joliet

have been a true blessing for me," Hicks wrote in a statement. "The relationships we have built, the faith we have shared, and the journey we have walked together are treasures I will carry with me to New York."

Hicks takes over after Dolan last week finalized a plan to establish a \$300 million fund to compensate victims of sexual abuse who had sued the archdiocese.

Dolan submitted his resignation in February, as required when he turned 75. But the Vatican often waits to make important leadership changes in dioceses if there is lingering

abuse litigation or other governance matters that need to be resolved by the outgoing bishop.

Hicks thanked Dolan for his backing during Thursday's news conference.

"He said to me, 'Ron, I want you to do well here, and you have all my support,'" Hicks said.

A call for solidarity with immigrants: Like Leo, who spent 20 years as a missionary in Peru, Hicks worked for five years in El Salvador heading a church-run orphanage program that operated in nine Latin American and

Turn to Archbishop, Page 5



Neal Nuber, of South Beloit, Illinois, watches a chemical fire at the Chemtool factory in Rockton, Illinois, from the J. Norman Jensen Forest Preserve in South Beloit on June 14, 2021. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

Illinois among states with most cuts to environmental agencies, report shows

By Christiana Freitag
Chicago Tribune

In the past 15 years, the Illinois Environmental Protection Agency has faced major budget cuts and a 21% decline in staffing, according to a recent report from the Environmental Integrity Project.

Illinois is among the 14 U.S. states with the most significant cuts to its state environmental agency, the report by the national nonprofit says. These states, which cross political and

geographic boundaries, will likely conduct fewer inspections and weaken protections against pollution, said Jen Duggan, executive director of the Environmental Integrity Project.

"These agencies ensure that our drinking water is clean and safe, that the air we breathe is free from harmful pollution, and that our rivers, lakes and coastal waters remain healthy," Duggan said. "Their efforts safeguard lives and enhance the overall quality of life for people across the United States."

As the administration of President Donald Trump pushes for a 55% cut to the U.S. EPA for fiscal year 2026, these findings should raise alarms for states, said Jennifer Walling, executive director of the Illinois Environmental Council, an organization that advocates for environmental policies.

"This report is a warning," Walling said. "If both lines of defense, our state agencies and the U.S. EPA, are weakened at

Turn to Cuts, Page 2

Justice Dept. sues Illinois over sensitive voter data

Alleges state's refusal to turn over info violates federal civil rights law

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

President Donald Trump's Department of Justice sued the executive director of the Illinois State Board of Elections on Thursday, alleging the board's refusal to release sensitive information on the state's roughly 8.3 million registered voters violated federal civil rights law.

The 10-page lawsuit, filed in federal court in Springfield, seeks a judge's order instructing state election officials to release to U.S. Attorney General Pam Bondi "the current electronic copy of Illinois computerized statewide voter registration list, with all fields, including each registrant's

full name, date of birth, residential address, and either their state driver's license number, the last four digits of their Social Security number" or other unique identifier.

The complaint, signed by Assistant Attorney General Harmmeet Dhillon, argues the federal Civil Rights Act gives Bondi "the sweeping power to obtain these records," which the Justice Department has said it needs as part of an investigation into the state's compliance with federal elections laws.

State Board of Elections spokesman Matt Dietrich declined to comment on the pending litigation, which makes Illinois one of the latest states to face a lawsuit from the Justice Department over the release of full voter rolls. The Illinois lawsuit was filed on the same day the Justice Department

Turn to Lawsuit, Page 5

INSIDE

Is potential move to Ind. a bridge too far?

Illinois lawmakers are skeptical about the Bears possibly moving to Indiana, while Hoosier leaders celebrate idea of luring them to their state. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

MAKING PLANS: Can the Bears owners find true happiness in an enclosed stadium off the Skyway? **Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports**



The Chicago Skyway Toll Bridge is seen from East 98th Street in South Chicago on Wednesday. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

